

Because an AIR application's assets are made up of content that runs equally well on multiple operating systems without having to be rebuilt (Flash documents, HTML pages, JavaScript, CSS code, and Acrobat PDF documents), a single application can run on all supported operating systems without having to be recompiled.

If you're using Flash Builder 4.5 to develop Flex applications, you don't necessarily have to install AIR on your development system because Flash Builder includes all the tools you need to compile, test, and debug an AIR application. But to fully install a completed application, the runtime must be installed.

You can install the runtime in two ways,

1. If you know you need AIR on your system, you can download the AIR installer from Adobe's Web site and install it on your system prior to installing any applications.
2. When you install an AIR application that uses a seamless installation badge, the application installer detects whether the runtime is already installed and, if not, offers to include the runtime installation along with the application.

Creating a Flex desktop application

You can create and deploy a desktop application with Flex using one of these strategies:

1. If you're using the free Flex SDK to build your Flex applications, you can use the free AIR SDK to package your applications for deployment.
2. If you're using Flash Builder to create your Flex applications, everything you need to package an AIR application is already included.

In this section, we will look at the steps for building a Flex desktop application project with Flash Builder. When you create a new Flex project in Flash Builder, you have the option of setting the Application type to Desktop. All MXML applications in such a project are designated as desktop applications and are tested and deployed with AIR.

In Flash Builder, you can't deploy a single application to both the desktop and the Web. The selection of Air-based or Web-based deployment is made at the project level, and after a project is configured as such, you can't change it without going back and rebuilding the project from scratch. If you do need to create a Flex application that's deployed with both architectures, consider creating three projects: one for the Web, one for the desktop, and one that's created as a Flex library project. The first two projects would have